

What's brewing?



As industries and recruiters focus on skills, online platforms offering executive courses are gaining prominence



Management-related and data science courses are the most sought-after programmes



Online executive courses act like a great career enhancer or career switcher



Technical courses that do not have enough supply in traditional degree structure are seeing high demand

SOURCE: INDUSTRY

AVERAGE PRICING OF COURSES

₹2-10

**LAKH
Management courses**

₹3-20

**LAKH+
Technology courses**

84 |

ferred not just by traditional institutes, but also by a bunch of up-and-coming edtech players.

For Divyashree Arumugam (name changed), a software engineer, this was a time for reflection. Having made the difficult decision to step away from her career to start a family, she saw her cousins—also software engineers—successfully transitioning into full-stack developers through online courses, landing lucrative and secure jobs. This ignited something within: an undeniable yearning to return to her work life. This spurred Arumugam to enrol herself in an executive programme for full-stack software development offered by a leading edtech firm. “The initial thought behind enrolling myself was to be in a field where work from home is easy and job opportunities are ample,” she tells *Business Today*. That worked out well. “Today, I live a well-balanced life where I manage home and kids along with a job,” she says.

Like Arumugam, the aspirations of India's young workforce—higher salary, better prospects and promotions, and more—are fuelling the growth of the online executive education industry, which saw a boom thanks to the pandemic. What has also helped is the flexibility that online education offers. Now, the blended form of learning online and offline has

led to executive courses becoming even more popular.

According to a study by market analysis platform Future Market Insights, the global executive education market is expected to reach \$109.6 billion by 2031 from \$37.8 billion in 2021, growing at a CAGR of 11.2 per cent in the forecast period. Experts believe that as the fear of job displacement by technology intensifies and the need to stay current with emerging trends grows, the online executive education segment will inevitably experience a boost. Consequently, the industry and recruiters are taking note of the talent emerging from these platforms.

THE PLAYERS

Until a few years ago, executive courses were offered by legacy universities such as the Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs), the Indian School of Business in Hyderabad, and the Great Lakes Institute of Management. The pandemic led to more courses emerging in the online space. Subsequently, edtech players entered the field, with the prominent names being upGrad, Emeritus, Great Learning, Hero Vired, and Scaler. They tied up with legacy universities that are valued in the job market to offer these courses. For instance, Emeritus has partnered with INSEAD and IIM Calcutta, among others, while upGrad has tied up with Deakin Business School,